



PRANAY RAJIV

caught hold of a couple of fielding nets, converted them to goals, and started a game of three-on-three football. Who is surprised?

The home players, though, chose to return to their basics, as they kickstarted a passionate game of one-pitch, one-hand tennis ball cricket right in front of their dressing room. Meanwhile, the Kerala players wrapped up their football game. But with the smog refusing to subside, there was still some time to bide. And thus began a game of tennis, if you could call it that.

The foot-volley nets retained their position. Two tennis racquets were acquired. But you need two more to play doubles, right? Out came two cricket bats, one the normal size and the other the shorter one used for fielding practice. Talk about innovation. Unlike the foot volley game, this was a struggle — to play and watch. The rallies were comically short, with the tennis ball bouncing all over the place. Soon, the smog dissipated, allowing the players to indulge in the sport they were actually paid to play.

IPL franchises keeping an eye on Ranji Trophy

As the IPL has grown in stature, the competition among franchises to find untapped young talent has only risen.

It has become customary, thus, for these teams to send their coaches, scouts and analysts to the different state-run T20 leagues through the year as well as the country's premier domestic T20 and 50-over tournaments — the Syed

Mushtaq Ali Trophy and Vijay Hazare Trophy, respectively.

But with the Ranji Trophy having kicked off the domestic season this time in an effort to retain the primacy of First-Class cricket, IPL franchises didn't really have an opportunity before the mega auction to track players and make prudent choices based on the domestic white-ball events. Nonetheless, they kept a close tab on the first five rounds of the Ranji season for any insight they could get on the players to back at the mega auction.

When Delhi played Tamil Nadu at the Arun Jaitley Stadium in October, Vikram Solanki (**left**), Gujarat Titans' Director of Cricket, was a keen observer from the media enclosure on all four days of the contest.

For the match between Delhi and Jharkhand in the fifth round, the Titans had assistant coaches Amit Bhandari and Narender Singh Negi at the venue. Even though it was with an eye on the IPL, the Ranji

Trophy is at least attracting greater interest than it has in recent seasons.

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